position in the Bhutan-Tibet-NEFA region and an appraisal of the Chinese reactions to Indian moves in the Dhola area. He stated that in view of our own build-up on the Nam Ka Chu, it was likely that the Chinese would push forward even more troops to supplement the two regiments that were currently reported to be behind the Thagla area. It was also anticipated that the Chinese could broaden the front and strike elsewhere in the NEFA region; and finally, they could retaliate in Ladakh, in which case they would attack our posts in the uncharted region of Chip Chap and Galwan rivers, for that would allow them to reach their 1960 claim line.

The foreign secretary, M. J. Desai, then reiterated Nehru's instructions about our posts in Ladakh and elsewhere—that no infringement of our border in NEFA was to be tolerated. As supplies and forces in the Dhola region were built up steadily, the Chinese had to be evicted even if the action ran the risk of the Chinese retaliating in Ladakh. The foreign secretary said the Chinese reaction in Ladakh was not expected to be beyond the capturing of a few posts.

The army chief then asked for the order to be given in writing.

ANNEXURE 1-A
Ministry of Defence

> At a meeting in MMD's [Minister, Ministry of Defence] room, this morning COAS raised the specific question whether action to evict the Chinese can be taken as soon as the Brigade has concentrated. The decision throughout has been, as discussed in the previous meetings, that the Army should prepare and throw the Chinese out as soon as possible. The COAS was accordingly directed to take action for the eviction of the Chinese in the Kameng Division of NEFA as soon as he was ready.
>
> 11987/JS(G)/62 COAS of 22-9-62
>
> HC Sarin
> Joint Secretary

It seems strange that the army chief should have insisted on a written order at this stage, especially since it would have to originate from a relatively junior bureaucrat. What is even more bizarre is that the final formal decision to take on China militarily was taken by a minister who did not even hold cabinet rank. It would almost seem that Thapar himself had reservations about Operation Leghorn, but he could not afford to come across to the political leadership as a 'meek' chief, especially since the